Atlanta Botanical Garden - Expansion

Phormium tenax 'Atropurpurea'

Purple New Zealand Flax, Bronze New Zealand Flax

Also known as: Phormium tenax Purpureum Group, Phormium tenax 'Purpureum' | Family: Asphodelaceae

Visitor Center: 2 **TOTAL 2**



HABIT



OTHER



LEAF



OTHER

QUICK FACTS

Plant Type: Not stated

Evergreen or deciduous
Evergreen

Growth & Size
Rate: Not stated
Size: 6–8 ft (1.8–2.4 m) high × 4–6 ft (1.2–1.8 m) wide; clump-forming with upright to arching sword-like leaves. Flower stalks taller

Sun

Water

Soil
Medium to low water once established; prefers moist but well-drained soils. Tolerates a range of soils including sandy, loam, and clay if drainage is good. Acid to alkaline pH

Zone 8a
Hardy in USDA Zones 8–11. Suitable for Atlanta Zone 8a with protection from extreme cold; one of the hardier Phormium forms

ORIGIN AND CHARACTERISTICS

Origin
Cultivar/selection of Phormium tenax, native to New Zealand (and Norfolk Island). Horticultural origin; purple-leaved form of the species. Historically used by Māori for fiber

Form
Evergreen perennial with stiff, upright to slightly arching, sword-shaped leaves that are dull coppery-purple to reddish-purple or bronze-purple. Dramatic architectural form. Tall panicles of reddish to dark red tubular flowers in late spring to summer on stalks rising above the foliage. No fall color change; foliage remains colored year-round. Fast to moderate growth. One of the larger and tougher New Zealand flax cultivars. Leaves can reach several feet long.
Flowers attract pollinators. Propagate by division

Foliage
Not stated

Flowers and fruit
Not stated

Bark
Not stated

PLANTING NOTES

Establishment

Plant in full sun to part shade with good drainage. Water regularly to establish, then tolerates moderate drought. Divide in spring or grow from seed. Excellent architectural specimen, for borders, containers, or mass plantings.
Give space to mature. Coastal and heat tolerant

HEALTH

Health

No serious problems stated. Generally tough and deer resistant.
May need protection in colder northern climates; foliage can be damaged by hard freezes below ~15°F.
Remove damaged leaves in late winter

Symptoms

None stated